

The Underlying features of rule/sovereignty under previous dynastic empires in South Asia, and then the system installed by the English East India Company.

As discussed in many lectures, pre-modern empires were dynastic empires, not national empires. In the Mughal and earlier Sultanate periods, sovereignty was vested in the ruler as personal authority, and emperors were seen as paternal figures, not something that was by popular consent. Unlike modern nations, pre-colonial states held territories by military force and tribute rather than democracy.

The Mughal State was centrally controlled but limited in local reach. By rotating jagir assignments, emperors prevented nobles from building independent power bases ^[1]. Mughal tax collection policies were lenient; hence, local lineage chiefs (zamindars) negotiated taxation with them, while peasants' condition varied from place to place ^[2]. Mughal ideology and practices were imperial; the emperor extended the Muslim power but did not wage systematic conversion campaigns. They drew on Islamic concepts, but also accommodated other minorities like Hindus. The Muslim population remained modest, and conversions were sporadic. Religious pluralism was promoted, and no violence against any community was tolerated. To sum it up, Mughal sovereignty meant divine kingship, Persianate court culture, and a predominantly agrarian tribute economy (an economy that is dependent both on farming and the raising of animals), rather than any modern concept of popular rule/Democracy.

In contrast, British Company rule replaced the older empire with a colonial state run by a corporation and later the crown. After winning Bengal (Buxar 1764), the company received the Mughal right to collect revenue (Diwani) in 1765. After this, a drastic change in the Indian Tax collection policy was noticed. In practice, this meant the Company ruled the province: the Mughal emperor and titular nawab lost all independent authority. From 1772 onward, the British “stood forth” as actual diwan, initiating direct administration ^[3]. After the revolt of 1857, the British abolished the dynasty altogether, unifying the sovereignty, including a monopoly of the armed forces held firmly in white hands. As a result, the Company claimed all the powers once split among kings, nawabs, and nobles.

The Mughal administrative system was entirely different from the British model. After the company took control, European-style bureaucracy and police were built, and new technologies like railways, telegraphs, and postal systems were also introduced. Lord Dalhousie and other officials saw these as “Tools of Integration” (for instance, railway lines to extend British trade/market and for the movement of troops). Tax revenue systems were altered: in Bengal in 1793, permanent settlement made zamindars “proprietors” with fixed revenues, radically altering Mughal land rights ^[4]. The overall effect was to extract wealth systematically, as Indian critics noted, the British “effectually do is to eat India... and carry away all they have acquired”. Unlike the Mughals, the company’s goal was to take control of India for the sake of profit, not noble services. The thought of liberating Indians came from the idea that Indians are trapped by despotism, priestcraft, and superstition. As Macaulay famously wrote (1835), Britain’s mission

was to produce a class of Indians “English in taste, in opinions, in morals and in intellect” [5]. Indian “Intellectuals” like Ram Mohan Roy embraced these aspects of this ideology. From 1772–1833, Roy drew on both Hindu scriptures and Enlightenment ideals to found the Brahmo Samaj, advocating a “rationalist... ‘modern’ India.” He allied with the British to push English education and the abolition of sati.

The Mughal economy remained fundamentally agrarian and self-sufficient. Land revenue was the main state income, but it was limited by local peasants and agricultural conditions. However, under the company’s rule, India’s economy was recognized to fit British capitalist needs. Revenues were maximized to fund the colonial government (leading to oppressive taxation and famines) [6]. Indian agriculture was turned towards export crops (cotton, indigo) for the British industry. British tariffs and trade policies favored imports of British-manufactured goods, undermining Indian textiles. Approximately, resources equivalent to 45 trillion dollars (today) were exported, during which thousands of Indians died due to famines i.e. The Great Bengal Famine (1770), Madras (1782–1783), Chalisa Famine (1783–1784) in Delhi and surrounding areas, Doji bara Famine (1791–1792) around Hyderabad, Agra Famine (1837–1838), Orissa Famine (1866), Bihar Famine (1873–1874), Southern India Famine (1876–1877), Bombay Famine (1905–1906) and the Bengal Famine (1943–1944). The first and worst of these was in 1770, which is estimated to have taken the lives of 10 million people. As mentioned in the lecture too, such a horrific act of mass killing never occurred before the British arrived, nor after they left.

Talking about religion, Mughal kings were Muslims but usually tolerated and patronized other religions/faiths, and as mentioned earlier, practiced religious pluralism. However, British rule altered the religious dynamics of this region in too many ways. They classified people by religion in censuses and laws, inadvertently hardening communal identities. These things were new to this region, which had never been practiced before. Nineteenth-century Hindu reformers responded to British critiques by reinterpreting ancient texts and downplaying caste divisions. For example, Ram Mohan Roy and later Gandhi shaped Hinduism into more unified ideologies. Meanwhile, among Muslims, movements like the Aligarh School represented a new ethno-religious consciousness. All of these concepts were unseen under the Mughal Rule.

Impacts on Indian Society

Mughal decline left India fragmented into princely states and federations. Company dominance imposed a different order: by 1858, the Mughal emperor was deposed, and princes were either annexed or became vassals to the British [6]. The 1857 Rebellion (the “Sepoy Mutiny”) crystallized the change: it convinced the British to tighten control. Dalhousie’s successors abolished the last pretenses of native rule and created a modern state apparatus. Law enforcement and revenue collection became uniform across provinces. As one historian notes, institutions fundamental to a modern state surveying, policing, and education for citizens, were introduced simultaneously in India and Britain in the mid-19th century. In practice, this meant native rulers could no longer

muster independent armies or conduct foreign policy; all political power flowed through the British administration.

Economically, colonial rule completely transformed the traditional patterns. The Mughal economy was largely agricultural with some vibrant urban industries. In contrast, the permanent settlement of 1793 and other tax policies often ruined peasants, as high fixed dues could not be met when harvests failed. The peasants and nawabs then used to take loans, which eventually led them to bankruptcy, hence selling their and which again cause several famines as mentioned earlier. Aristocrats who understood British methods (often brahmins and Kayastha employees) became the new landowners. Ostensibly, there was “modernization” of India by working on railways and infrastructure, but in reality, it was to carry goods. Trade policies were also changed; Indian agriculture supplied raw cotton, indigo, and opium to Britain, while Indian weavers faced stiff competition from British textiles. Nationalists criticized these changes sharply. Dadabhai Naoroji’s famous “drain theory” summarized it: the Raj was siphoning India’s wealth abroad ^[7].

Colonial society was also racially stratified. Europeans used to live apart (in “Civil Lines” and uphill stations) and treated Indians with racism. A Western-educated elite emerged at the top. Missionary schools and Christian morality began to influence social norms, which, combined with Western liberal thought, gave rise to social reform movements ^[8]. But there were counter movements too, some Indian conservatives objected to the idea of tolerance, British interference in religion and social customs. Religious Pluralism ended soon after the British took control, and the state took a subtler role. A significantly more important part is that they disestablished the relationship between throne and faith; the queen now styled herself as “empress of India”, secular in law. Moreover, only in the British era was communal politics introduced, rulers started using religious differences to their advantage, and censuses quantified religious populations. What breached India was the rising consciousness of religion as a social and political marker.

In conclusion, British rule was based on capitalism, racism, and on exploitation of Indians; they imposed centralized colonial state law and modern bureaucracy. In contrast, dynastic empires in South Asia rested on hereditary monarchy, religious pluralism, and agrarian tribute. Ideologically, the older empires projected cosmic or divine order, while the British proclaimed liberal-racial superiority. Practically, the consequences were stark: local peoples lost traditional autonomy, the economy was restructured for export (often disastrously for peasants), and society was remade along new lines (education, law, communication). All of these changes had profound political, economic, social, and religious impacts on Indian life ^[9].

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